Word Choice & Revision

Concept

Revise vague, inflated or unsuitable wording so the reader can understand exactly what you mean.

Review, not a ban

The source lists words to avoid in formal essays. Treat them as prompts to check purpose and precision, not forbidden words in every genre.

First person

I is useful in reflection and personal narrative. Follow the assignment for other forms.

Dialogue tags

Said is often clear and unobtrusive. Alternatives should accurately name speech; a person cannot literally "grin" a sentence.

Intensifiers

Instead of automatically replacing very, consider a precise adjective or a concrete detail.

Absolute claims

Words such as always and everyone need evidence. Qualify a claim when appropriate.

Grammar

Write could have or could've, not could of. Use used to for a past habit; after did/didn't, use use to.

Word Choice & Revision

Example 1 | original model

Revise: Everyone thinks the room is really nice.

Solution / why it works

1. Problem: everyone is unsupported, really adds little, and nice is vague.

2. Revision: The room's wide desks and bright windows make it comfortable for reading.

3. The revision gives observable features instead of an unsupported universal claim.

Word bank | Words to review in formal writing

a bit	cheap	get
a lot	completely	go
about	could of	goes
absolutely	crap	going
all	did	gone
almost	does	gonna
always	duh	good
amazing	every	got
anyway	everybody	gotta
anyways	everyone	great
awesome	everything	gross
bad	feel	hang out
barely	finally	hate
believe	fine	have got
big	fun	here are
bummed	funny	hopefully

Word Choice & Revision

Word bank | Words to review in formal writing (continued)

how come
I
just
kind of
kinda
like
literally
loser
lots
luv
me
merely
my
myself
need
never
nice
not
of course
often
OK or okay
only
perfect
pissed
pretty
psycho
really
replied
said
screw up
short
small
so
some
sort of
stuff
stupid
sucks
tall
that
the end
then
thing
think
totally
use to
used to
very
wanna
well
went
whatever
wonderful
yah
yeah
you
your

Word bank | Speech / reporting verbs

acknowledged
added
addressed
admitted
admonished
advised
agreed
alleged
allowed
announced
answered
approved
argued
asked
assented
asserted
assumed
assured
attested
avowed
babbled

Word Choice & Revision

Word bank | Speech / reporting verbs (continued)

bantered
bargained
began
begged
bellowed
blurted
boasted
called
cautioned
chattered
chided
claimed
commanded
commented
complained
confessed
confided
continued
contradicted
countered
cried
debated
decided
declared
demanded
denied
denounced
described
dictated
directed
disclosed
disrupted
divulged
drawled
droned
elaborated
emphasized
enjoined
entreated
enunciated
estimated
explained
exposed
expressed
faltered
feared
foretold
fumed
gasped
giggled
glared
grinned
growled
grunted
gushed
held
hissed
implied
indicated
inferred
insisted
instructed
interrupted
itemized
joked
lamented
laughed
lectured
lied
maintained
mentioned
mimicked
moaned
mumbled
murmured
mused
muttered
nagged
narrated
noted
notified
objected
observed
orated
ordered
petitioned
pleaded

Word Choice & Revision

Word bank | Speech / reporting verbs (continued)

pled
pointed out
prayed
predicted
proclaimed
professed
prompted
ranted
reassured
rebuked
reciprocated
refuted
related
remonstrated
repeated
replied
responded
restated
resumed
retorted
returned
revealed
roared
ruled
sanctioned
scoffed
scolded
screamed
shouted
shrieked
sighed
snapped
sneered
snorted
snubbed
sobbed
spoke
sputtered
stammered
stated
stipulated
stormed
stressed
stuttered
suggested
taunted
teased
thought
threatened
told
urged
uttered
ventured
vowed
wailed
warned
whimpered
whispered
wondered
yelled

Word bank | Alternatives to very (check meaning)

abnormally
astonishingly
bitterly
chiefly
curiously
deeply
especially
exceedingly
extraordinarily
fully
generally
hugely
immeasurably
increasingly
incredibly
infinitely
intensely
mightily

Word Choice & Revision

Word bank | Alternatives to very (check meaning) (continued)

mildly
normally
oddly
ordinarily
particularly
powerfully
rarely
regularly
remarkably
richly
scarcely
severely
shockingly
slightly
strangely
strongly
surely
surprisingly
truly
uncommonly
universally
unusually

Word bank | Positive qualities

acceptable
adequate
advantageous
appropriate
beneficial
benevolent
bright
capable
careful
clever
considerable
decent
delightful
enjoyable
excellent
exceptional
expert
first-class
first-rate
fit
glowing
healthy
helpful
high-quality
lovely
pleasant
polite
reliable
respectable
select
skilled
sound
sufficient
superior
thriving
top
trustworthy
upright
upstanding
virtuous
worthy

Word Choice & Revision

Word bank | Humour & enjoyment

amusing	exciting	pleasure
comical	hilarious	quaint
curious	humorous	strange
droll	joyful	unusual
enjoyable	odd	weird
enjoyment	peculiar	witty
entertaining	pleasurable	

Word bank | Sadness

bitter	forlorn	miserable
blue	gloomy	moved
cheerless	glum	pensive
dejected	grief-stricken	regretful
depressing	heartbreaking	somber
despondent	heart rending	sorrowful
disappointing	heavy-hearted	sorry
distressing	melancholy	wistful

Word bank | Negative qualities

abominable	cruel	disagreeable
abysmal	debauched	displeasing
appalling	defective	distressing
atrocious	deleterious	dreadful
awful	deplorable	evil
base	depraved	fearful
black	destructive	foul
corrupt	detrimental	frightful

Word Choice & Revision

Word bank | Negative qualities (continued)

harmful
hopeless
horrid
hurtful
ill
immoral
impaired
inauspicious
incompetent
inferior
iniquitous
injurious
lamentable
lousy
mediocre
misbehaving
mischievous
nasty
naughty
negative
offensive
painful
peccant
pitiful
poor
putrid
reprobate
rotten
sinful
sorry
terrible
troublesome
uncongenial
unfavorable
unpleasant
unpropitious
unsatisfactory
unskilled
unspeakable
unsympathetic
vicious
vile
villainous
wicked
wrong

Word bank | Amount & frequency

abundance
common
considerable
consistently
countless
diverse
few
frequently
habitually
hardly
infrequently
innumerable
meager
meagre
minority
myriad
numerous
occasionally
paltry
plenty
prevalent
profuse
rarely
repeatedly
scant
scarcely
seldom
several
slight
smatter
sparse
sporadic
sprinkling

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Practice | your turn

1. Revise "The thing was very bad" by naming the object and its exact problem.

2. Write a sentence where said is the best choice, and one where whispered is justified.

3. Find one absolute claim in your writing and qualify it or add evidence.

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Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

Possible revision: The chair's cracked backrest made it unsafe to use.

2

Said can be neutral; whispered specifically indicates low-volume speech.

3

Replace unsupported everyone with a defensible group, or support the claim with relevant evidence.

Source & editing note

Words to Avoid to Improve Word Choice in Writing.pdf | 3 supplied pages.

Source credited to Simply Novel in the supplied PDF. Concepts reorganized and condensed; repeated templates consolidated. Examples, practice and sample answers here are original additions, not copied student work.

Exact repeated list entries were consolidated and obvious extraction/spelling errors repaired. Alternatives may differ in meaning, grammar or tone.